

Micah Sheats
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Dont Make Me Think Reading Notes

Chapter 1

- “Dont make me think” is the first law of usability meaning that the best way to make a website usable is not to make the user have to think about what it is, it should be obvious
- Things like buttons should be self-evident
- We aim to eliminate question marks in the user's head

Chapter 2

- “In all the time I’ve spent watching people use the Web, the thing that has struck me most is the difference between how we think people use Web sites and how they actually use them”
- The reality is that people are only scanning text and clicking the thing that looks sort of like what they are looking for
- People are only interested in a fraction of what is on a given page
- There are words that are hardwired into us to catch our attention like “free” “sex” and our own name
- We don't make optimal decisions, we satifce meaning we choose the first reasonable option
- We don’t understand things, we muddle through because it usually works
- If we find something that works, we stick to it, people have pre-existing beliefs and habits regarding website uses

Chapter 3

- Take advantage of conventions, Create effective visual hierarchies, Break pages up into clearly defined areas, Make it obvious what’s clickable, Eliminate distractions, and Format content to support scanning
- Essentially, take advantage of preexisting notions people have about websites such as the company logo being in the top left, the menu being across the top or down the left side etc
- In general, do not try to reinvent the wheel, occasionally there is a really good idea, but not often
- However, clarity trumps consistency, if you can make something clearer by breaking convection, do it
- Pages should have clear visual hierarchies where the more important something is, the more prominent it is
- Things that are related logically should be related visually
- Things can be nested visually to show what is part of what

- Break up the page into clearly defined sections, make it obvious what is clickable
- Keep the noise down and format text to support scanning, use short paragraphs, highlight key terms, and use bulleted lists

Chapter 4

- It would seem that it is less about how many clicks it takes to get somewhere and more about how hard each click is
- Confidence that they are on the right track is very important for users
- It is also important to not confront the user with too many choices as once such as a login, a join screen, and a skip option all on one screen
- Guidance is best when it is brief, timely, and unavoidable

Chapter 5

- Omit unnecessary words. A sentence should contain no unnecessary words and a paragraph should contain no unnecessary sentences
- Words being on a webpage suggest that you need to read them
- No happy talk, text must contain useful substance
- Get rid of unnecessary words, use the bare minimum to maximize scanability